Gauba were looped in, so that planning for measures to be taken could begin. Mishra, unassuming and low-key, a 1972-batch Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer belonging to the Gujarat Cadre, worked closely with Modi in several capacities over the last two decades. In 2001, he was the then chief minister Modi's principal secretary when the devastating earthquake shook the Kutch region of Gujarat and was largely instrumental in shaping relief and rehabilitation policies, which helped the people emerge from helplessness and changed the face of Kutch. He held several positions thereafter mostly focusing on his expertise in disaster management for which he recently received the United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction's (UNDRR) prestigious Sasakawa Award in 2019. He was brought into the PMO as additional principal secretary in 2014 after the prime minister's landslide victory in the general elections. Whereas Gauba, a 1962-batch IAS officer, has held a mixed bag of high-profile appointments in several ministries, namely Home Affairs, Urban Development and Defence.

On 8 January, news arrived that although the Chinese authorities had ruled out MERS (Middle East Respiratory Syndrome), seasonal influenza and some other respiratory pathogens, SARS was still a serious possibility. Information also came in that the case count had now gone up to 50 people.[11] Dr Paul and Prof. VijayRaghavan agreed that the doubling rate — the number of days in which the number of infected would double—did not look comforting at all. As with most information that came his way, Dr Paul played devil's advocate and decided that he wasn't convinced that all these cases were occurances of animal-to-human transmission. The statistics told a different story; human-to-human transmission was a more likely cause of such a rapid doubling rate which would increase the likelihood of a major outbreak. He would divulge his doubt to the prime minister when he would see him, he decided. More importantly, Hong Kong, Taiwan, Singapore and the Amur region in Russia had already begun border screening of passengers arriving from Wuhan. He needed to check with the PMO if India should wait a few more days for the story to fully develop, or begin similar precautionary measures. After all, we do share a land border with China.

By early second week of January, confirmed cases in the Wuhan region had gone up to 59 and information from our Intelligence sources on ground had also come in; there was an increased demand for N95 masks in the Hubei province. Sources added that 'mysterious viral pneumonia in Wuhan'